

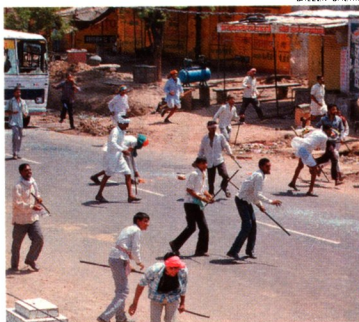


PRANOD PUSHPAKA

ssion. Created to amend the antiquated Police Act of 1861, the commission has pushed for better training for police forces and recommended the use of non-lethal means for mob dispersal, like shotguns and rubber bullets.

An array of non-lethal mob dispersal devices—rubber bullets, plastic bullets, flash and stun grenades—is on display at the headquarters of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) in Delhi. They sting and injure rioters, but don't kill. In short, every apparatus this specialised riot-control force successfully used to disperse mobs without causing a single casualty since its inception in 1992. Such basic, non-lethal equipment have been produced within the country but

SALEEM SHERI



SLEDGEHAMMER: A constable wields a .303 rifle; (right) riots in Rajasthan knees. Worse, they had defied established procedures and had opened fire from their self-loading rifles (SLRs) without seeking permission from their superiors. Hyderabad Police Commissioner Balwinder Singh later categorically denied having passed any such order.

Once the firing begins, deaths are inevitable. Policemen come equipped with the .303 Enfield rifle and the 7.62 mm SLR, whose bullets travel at supersonic speed and can kill a person over 1 km away. Both these weapons are hand-me-downs from the Indian Army which discarded the .303 in the late 1960s and the SLR in the late 1990s. For the Indian police to continue using them for crowd control is the equivalent of using sledgehammers to swat flies.

"We must not use lethal arms against people who have been temporarily misled," says former Delhi police commissioner Ajai Raj Sharma, a member of the National Police Commi-

are not available even to the state police forces who comprise the first line of response during a riot. "When a recruit joins us, we spend the first three months training him to control crowds without using firearms," says Dulal Chandra Dey, inspector-general of police, RAF. Outside of this 10-battalion force, crowd-control follows the same outdated mode as under the British raj. Senior officers insist that police firing is effective in restoring peace. Even shoot at sight orders have an impact, according to a police officer in Rajasthan. "The frequent use of force is generally a sign of poor policing," argues Dr Arvind Verma, former IPS officer and now Associate Professor at Indiana University, US. "Organisationally, the Indian police can be made less trigger-happy. To some extent, this can be done by determined field officers who will have to lead from the front," he adds.

The apparently unconscionable use of infantry weapons against citizenry, which invites charges of a trigger-happy police force and the lack of equipment, is only the tip of the iceberg. Police reforms suggested by several committees are yet to be implemented and a heavily politicised, demoralised police force finds itself incapable of preventive action. Least of all the police personnel who are expected to respond to every situation, from crime detection to VIP security to crowd control.

With the National Police Commission merely outlining the broader picture, it is left to the individual state governments to interpret how best to tackle riots. The need of the hour is for state governments to create their own specialised riot-control force out of existing forces, like the Punjab Armed Police or the Rajasthan Armed Constabulary. "If states insist law and order is a state subject, they must also create their own specialised riot-control battalions," says Sharma.

Equipped with special non-lethal riot-control equipment, well versed in unarmed combat and highly trained to withstand extreme provocation, these battalions could have their own mobile medical staff and ambulances to administer aid to riot victims. The aim would be to achieve maximum results with minimum force—in sharp contrast to today's riot control techniques.

with Rohit Parihar and Amarnath K. Menon

WHAT IS REQUIRED

An array of indigenously produced, non-lethal crowd control devices:

TEAR GAS Discharged by a grenade, the gas irritates the eye and obstructs the respiratory system, causing temporary incapacitation.

PLASTIC BULLETS Regular bullets with a plastic warhead, can only cause injuries.

RUBBER BULLETS Fired from a riot gas gun, these rounds are smaller than a Coke can. These cause injury, but do not kill.

STUN GRENADES Emit a flash and loud bang but are harmless. Used for temporarily disorienting rioters.

PLASTIC PELLETS Fired out of a shotgun, these bruise rioters but cannot kill them.

ELECTRIC PROD An electrically-charged baton that emits a harmless electric shock.